Leadership Tool: Creating a Best Practice Agenda

Meetings have long been the subject of satire, with countless jokes and cartoons mocking their inefficiencies. However, behind this humor lies a serious issue that impacts the effectiveness and well-being of both teams and organizations. Interviews with executives from a range of industries, including high tech, retail, and pharmaceuticals, have revealed a common feeling of being overwhelmed by the sheer volume and length of meetings. These leaders describe their workweeks as chaotic and exhausting, with one executive stating, "I cannot get my head above water to breathe during the week" (Perlow et al., 2017). Research backs these anecdotes, showing that meetings have steadily increased in both length and frequency over the past 50 years. Today, executives spend an average of 23 hours per week in meetings—more than double the time spent in the 1960s (Perlow et al., 2017).

MEETING Agenda

ATTENDEES:
- Alexander Aronowitz
- Kyrie Petrakis
- Jonathan Patterson
- Korina Villanueva

DATE: 24 JANUARY 2026
TIME: 8.30 AM - 1:20 PM
PLACE: 123 ANYWHERE ST., ANY CITY

Agenda	Topic	Person In Charge
WELCOME AND INTRODUCTIONS	• Opening remarks • Brief introductions of each attendee	Alexander Aronowitz
PROJECT OVERVIEW	• Presentation of project goals and objectives • Discussion about the project scope and key deliverables	Kyrie Petrakis
TIMELINE AND MILESTONES	• Review of the project timeline • Discussion of major milestones and deadlines	Jonathan Patterson
ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES	• Outline of team roles and responsibilities • Assignment of specific tasks and duties	Kyrie Petrakis
COMMUNICATION PLAN	• Explanation of communication channels and protocols • Establishing a regular meeting schedule and reporting methods	Jonathan Patterson
Q&A AND OPEN DISCUSSION	• Opportunity for attendees to ask questions and provide feedback • Open discussion on any concerns or suggestions	Korina Villanueva
NEXT STEPS AND ACTION ITEMS	• Summary of key decisions and action items • Confirmation of the next meeting date and time	Aaron Loeb

However, meetings are an essential aspect of organizational communication, providing a dedicated space for team members to collaborate, align on goals, and share critical information. They facilitate real-time discussions that help clarify priorities, address challenges, and make collective decisions that drive progress. In a fast-paced work environment, meetings enable leaders and teams to ensure everyone is on the same page, fostering transparency and accountability. By providing an opportunity for open dialogue, meetings allow individuals to express ideas, ask questions, and resolve misunderstandings, creating a stronger, more unified approach to achieving organizational goals.

The necessity of meetings also lies in their role in fostering team cohesion and maintaining motivation. Regular face-to-face or virtual interactions help build relationships, trust, and a sense of belonging among team members. In collaborative settings, meetings encourage diverse perspectives, enabling innovation and problem-solving. They are also a platform for leaders to provide feedback, recognize achievements, and address concerns, which helps to improve morale and ensure continuous engagement. While meetings must be purposeful and well-structured to avoid time waste, when conducted effectively, they are a powerful tool for driving productivity and maintaining organizational momentum.

The true cost of poorly run meetings is significant, and not just in terms of lost time. Research by Simone Kauffeld and Nale Lehmann-Willenbrock (2012) found that dysfunctional meeting behaviors—such as going off-topic, constant complaints, and unproductive criticism—are linked to lower levels of market share, reduced innovation, and less stable employment. Similarly, Steven Rogelberg (2006) and his colleges at the University of North Carolina found a direct

correlation between how workers feel about the effectiveness of their meetings and their overall job satisfaction. When meetings consistently fail to improve communication and collaboration, they actually work against the intended goals, leading to frustration, disengagement, and ultimately, a hit to team morale.

Understanding the Purpose and Goals of the Meeting Agenda

Before creating a meeting agenda, leaders must first take the critical step of defining the meeting's purpose. This clarity sets the foundation for a focused, effective discussion. Is the meeting meant to share information, brainstorm, solve a problem, or make a decision? Each purpose requires a different approach and set of expectations from participants. When the purpose is vague, meetings become aimless, leading to frustration and wasted time. Understanding why the meeting is happening and what needs to be accomplished helps ensure that the meeting stays on track and that attendees can contribute meaningfully.

Aligning the meeting’s agenda with its purpose is key to creating structure and setting expectations. For example, if the goal is to solve a problem, then the agenda should prioritize discussions that lead to identifying solutions. Alternatively, if the meeting is meant to share information, then it should focus on concise updates and reserve time for questions or clarifications. When leaders fail to align the agenda with the purpose, participants may leave the meeting feeling confused about what was accomplished or their role in the next steps. By clearly communicating the purpose upfront, leaders ensure that participants are mentally prepared for the type of discussion at hand, whether it involves critical decision-making or simply disseminating information.

One of the best ways to ensure that meeting goals are actionable and clear is to use the SMART framework: Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound. This method not only clarifies what the meeting should accomplish but also keeps the meeting grounded in realistic, time-sensitive outcomes. For instance, rather than setting a vague agenda item like "Budget Review," a SMART goal would specify, "Identify three areas where we can reduce spending by 10% by the end of the fiscal year." This goal gives participants a concrete target and ensures that the conversation stays focused on actionable outcomes, reducing the likelihood of discussions veering off track or becoming overly theoretical.

Using SMART goals also helps guide the flow of the meeting. For example, a project update meeting could include the following goals: "Specific: Provide updates on project progress. Measurable: Each team member gives a 5-minute update. Achievable: Time limit of 30 minutes. Relevant: Ensure all team members are aligned on project timelines. Time-bound: Meeting concludes in 45 minutes." In this scenario, time is carefully allocated, and expectations are clear. Similarly, a strategic planning session might use a goal like: "Specific: Brainstorm new marketing strategies for the upcoming quarter. Measurable: Generate at least five new marketing ideas. Achievable: Include cross-functional team members for diverse input. Relevant: Focus on strategies that support company growth goals. Time-bound: Conclude in 1 hour with actionable

steps." This framework keeps the meeting grounded in achievable outcomes while allowing for meaningful contributions from all team members.

Structuring the Agenda for Clarity and Flow

Once the purpose of the meeting is clearly defined, structuring the agenda becomes essential for ensuring optimal clarity and flow. The order in which topics are addressed should reflect their importance and urgency. This ensures that critical discussions happen when participants are most attentive and engaged. Research in meeting effectiveness consistently shows that content addressed early in an agenda garners the most attention and energy (Perlow et al., 2017). As a result, it's crucial to front-load the agenda with high-priority items to maximize the value of the meeting.

High-Impact Topics First:

Begin the agenda with high-impact discussions or decisions that require strategic thinking and thoughtful input from participants. For example, if the meeting's goal is to make pivotal decisions about a project, allocate more time for those discussions at the beginning when attention levels are highest. By tackling key issues early, you also avoid the risk of running out of time for important decisions or rushing through them as energy wanes toward the end of the meeting. Starting with significant issues also signals to attendees that their time is valued, helping to foster a sense of urgency and focus. One major misstep often happens in reoccurring meetings where the agenda is set the same way time and time again. This lacks the priority setting that is essential to address high impact topics first.

Address Less Critical Items Toward the End:

Administrative updates or routine tasks that don't require deep strategic thinking can be saved for the latter part of the meeting. These less critical items, while necessary, can be handled more efficiently when participants' energy naturally begins to dip. By placing these discussions near the end, you ensure that the bulk of the meeting's time is dedicated to what truly matters. This structure also leaves room for overrun on earlier, high-priority discussions without jeopardizing essential decision-making time. As a result, participants feel the meeting was a good use of their time, avoiding the common complaint that meetings are unproductive.

Organizing by Time and Topic:

One essential tool in a leader's toolbelt is time blocking. Assigning specific time blocks to each agenda item is a powerful way to keep the meeting on track and maintain focus. Leaders should include realistic time estimates based on the complexity and importance of each topic. For instance, topics that require in-depth discussion might need 30 minutes, while quick updates could be limited to 10 minutes. However, flexibility is key—allow for buffer time to accommodate unanticipated discussions or questions. This time management ensures the meeting flows smoothly without cutting short essential conversations or extending the meeting unnecessarily. Additionally, this sets an example of how time blocking can be used for others in the meeting.

Time Allocations:

Carefully consider the time required for each agenda item. Not every topic warrants the same amount of discussion. For instance, a complex strategic decision may need a 45-minute block, while a quick update can be covered in 5–10 minutes. Accurate time allocation prevents the meeting from derailing due to overlong discussions on minor issues and allows participants to stay focused on the agenda's goals.

Logical Sequencing:

On individual topics, start with broader discussion that require higher levels of creativity and strategic input, and gradually narrow the focus toward more specific action items and next steps. This logical progression helps guide participants from high-level thinking to practical decision-making, creating a natural flow in the conversation. By the end of the meeting, participants should leave with a clear understanding of decisions made, actions to be taken, and the overall direction of the project or issue at hand. This approach not only increases clarity but also boosts engagement, ensuring that each part of the meeting builds on the previous discussions.

Key Components of an Effective Agenda

A well-structured agenda includes several essential components that help guide the meeting and keep participants engaged. These components ensure that the meeting is organized, focused, and productive.

- ***Meeting Title and Date/Time***: Clearly articulating the meeting title and specifying the exact date and time are fundamental to ensuring participants understand the meeting's purpose and when it will occur. This information not only sets the context but also signals the importance of the meeting, helping attendees prioritize their time and

come prepared for the relevant discussion. Additionally, specifying whether the meeting is in-person, virtual, or hybrid and providing necessary links or location details prevents any last-minute confusion.

- ***Participants and Assigned Roles***: Identifying the attendees and their specific roles during the meeting promotes clarity and accountability. Beyond just listing attendees, it's beneficial to assign key roles like facilitator, timekeeper, and note-taker, which encourages participation and helps structure the meeting's flow. Careful consideration should be given to who is invited, ensuring only essential participants are included to keep the meeting focused and efficient. Large gatherings often result in distractions and extended timeframes, so limiting attendance to those directly involved in the discussion or decisions is critical.
- ***Meeting Objectives and Desired Outcomes***: Outlining a clear purpose for the meeting and specifying the desired outcomes help participants focus on the objectives from the start. A well-defined purpose prevents the meeting from becoming aimless, while setting tangible goals encourages actionable results. This could include decisions that need to be made, problems to be solved, or information to be shared, all of which ensure alignment among attendees and foster a results-driven atmosphere.
- ***Structured Agenda and Discussion Points***: Creating a detailed, itemized agenda with clear descriptions of each discussion topic ensures that the meeting flows logically and smoothly. By grouping related items together and arranging them in a coherent sequence, participants can follow the discussion more effectively. This structure also allows for focused conversations, preventing digressions and enhancing the overall productivity of the meeting. Including a numbered list helps guide the pacing of the session.
- ***Time Allocation for Each Topic***: Allocating specific time slots for each agenda item is critical for maintaining the meeting's efficiency and ensuring that discussions remain concise. Realistic time estimates provide structure to the conversation, encouraging participants to stay on point. Managing time well minimizes the risk of one topic dominating the meeting, allowing for a more balanced discussion and ensuring that all key points are addressed.
- ***Discussion Leads and Topic Ownership***: Assigning ownership for each agenda item by designating a specific presenter or lead ensures that responsibilities are distributed effectively and that topics are given appropriate attention. Having a designated leader for each discussion point ensures that the conversation stays on track and that the necessary information is presented. This also encourages accountability, as the owner is responsible for guiding the discussion and delivering relevant insights.
- ***Pre-Meeting Preparation and Resource Distribution***: Providing participants with pre-meeting reading materials, data, or reports ahead of time ensures that everyone comes to the meeting well-prepared. Sharing documents in advance allows participants to digest complex information, formulate questions, and offer meaningful

contributions during the meeting. Preparation is crucial for informed decision-making and fosters more effective and efficient discussions.

- ***Closing Summary and Action Plan***: Ending the meeting with a summary of key decisions, assigned action items, and deadlines is essential for ensuring that discussions translate into concrete results. This final step reinforces accountability by clearly defining who is responsible for specific follow-up tasks and setting clear timelines for completion. A concise review of outcomes also helps participants leave with a sense of direction and purpose, maintaining the momentum generated during the meeting.

Conclusion

Ineffective meetings, often the subject of humor, have serious consequences for productivity, well-being, and organizational performance. While many view meetings as necessary for collaboration and alignment, poorly managed ones can undermine these goals, leading to frustration and disengagement. To combat this, organizations must rethink their approach by clearly defining the purpose of each meeting and structuring agendas with clarity and flow. Prioritizing high-impact topics early, using frameworks like SMART goals, and managing time effectively can transform meetings into valuable opportunities for decision-making and collaboration. With intentional planning, meetings can drive better outcomes, enhance team cohesion, and contribute to a more positive work environment.

References

Kauffeld, S., & Lehmann-Willenbrock, N. (2012). Meetings matter: Effects of team meetings on team and organizational success. *Small group research*, *43*(2), 130-158.

Perlow, L. A., Hadley, C. N., & Eun, E. (2017). Stop the meeting madness: How to free up time for meaningful work. *Harvard Business Review*, *95*(4), 62-69.

Rogelberg, S. G., Leach, D. J., Warr, P. B., & Burnfield, J. L. (2006). " Not another meeting!" Are meeting time demands related to employee well-being?. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, *91*(1), 83.